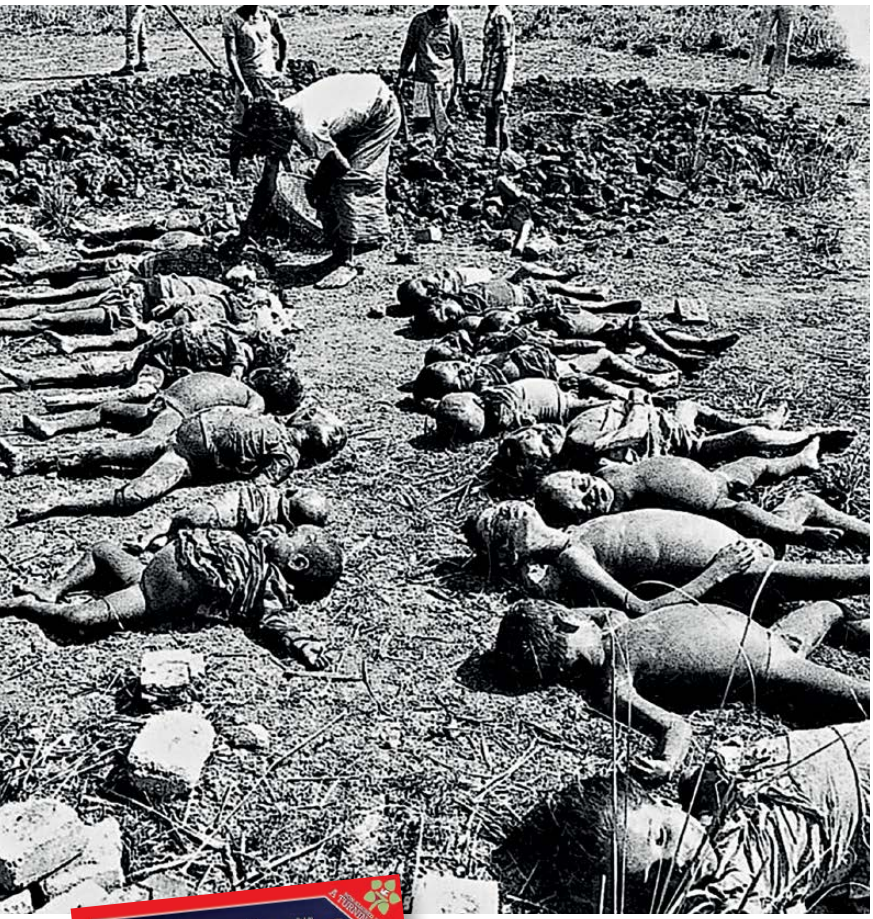
BHAWAN SINGH





Assam: A State Ravaged
Mar. 15, 1983

"On that fateful Friday, the thought of death hovered over Nellie and surrounding villages like a vulture. At around eight in the morning, a huge armed mob had surrounded the village, their 'daos' glinting in the morning sun. Cries of 'Jai ai ahom!', the rallying slogan of the anti-foreigner agitation, rent the air.... As the daos rose and fell with monotonous precision, women and children tumbled in heaps in the rice paddies."

cre which took place in Assam on February 18, 1983, just 45 km from the state capital. In a span of seven hours, thousands of Bengali Muslims were slaughtered across 14 villages of Nagaon district. The violence was perpetrated by rural peasants, whose contention was that the Muslims were Bangladeshi immigrants and illegal settlers. Assam was already on the boil after voting rights were given to four million Bengali Muslims, and anti-outsider sentiment was running high. The decision to hold an assembly election—chief election commissioner Ram Krishna Trivedi cited constitutional exigency—in a charged political environment proved to be fateful. Most of the dead were women, children and the elderly—those who couldn't get away quickly enough. ■

BLEAK MOMENTS

INDIA TODAY ARCHIVES



GEETA AND SANJAY CHOPRA KIDNAPPING AND MURDER, 1978

The double murder of siblings Geeta and Sanjay Chopra (top), mere teenagers, who had been kidnapped for ransom by Ranga and Billa (above) while on their way to participate in a radio programme, shook the conscience of the nation.

BHAGALPUR BLINDINGS, 1980

Police in Bihar's Bhagalpur pierced the eyes of 31 undertrials and poured acid into their eye sockets. For the first time, the Supreme Court awarded compensation for human rights violations.



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